

Chocolate Truffles

For the ganache

Generous 2 cups (18 ounces; 500 grams) heavy cream
21 ounces (600 grams) bittersweet chocolate, finely chopped
Generous 1/4 cup (2 ounces; 60 grams) Grand Marnier or Štoli Razberi
vodka (optional)

To enrobe the truffles

18 ounces (500 grams) bittersweet chocolate, tempered
18 ounces (500 grams) white chocolate, tempered

To garnish the truffles

2 cups (8 ounces; 230 grams) Dutch-processed unsweetened cocoa
powder, sifted
2 1/2 cups (9 ounces; 250 grams) shredded sweetened coconut, toasted
(see note, below)
About 2 cups (8 ounces; 230 grams) toasted nuts, finely chopped (see
note, below)

— preparation —

Heat the heavy cream in a 2-quart heavy-bottomed saucepan until bubbles begin to form around the edge of the pan. Make sure that you have chopped the chocolate as finely as possible to allow it to melt quickly and easily. Place the chopped chocolate in a medium-size mixing bowl. Make a ganache by pouring about half of the hot cream over the chocolate and letting it sit for 30 seconds to melt the chocolate. Then slowly whisk until smooth and homogenous. Do not add all of the hot cream to the cold chocolate at once; the shock of the temperature extremes would cause the fat in the chocolate to separate. As the chocolate melts, you will see some elasticity if there is no fat separation. This means the chocolate still has an emulsion; the fat molecules are still holding together. If the ganache separates, it loses its elasticity, collapses, and becomes very liquid. I use a hand-held immersion blender to ensure a smooth ganache and to keep the emulsion of the chocolate. Add the remaining cream gradually and mix until all of the hot cream is incorporated and the ganache is smooth and homogenous.

If the ganache separates, it is very easy to fix. Simply add a small amount of cold cream and whisk well. This will bring the ganache back together. The ganache should be thick, shiny, and smooth. Add the desired flavoring and mix until fully incorporated. Pour the ganache onto a plastic wrap-covered baking sheet and spread evenly with a rubber spatula. Cover the ganache with plastic wrap and allow it to cool for at least 4 hours at room temperature. I usually make the ganache at the end of the day and let it cool overnight. As it cools, it will thicken and set.

When the ganache has cooled to the consistency of toothpaste, scrape it into a pastry bag fitted with a 1/2-inch plain tip. Do not stir the ganache when you do this. Incorporating air by stirring will cause the ganache to harden. Pipe 1-inch-diameter mounds spaced 1 inch apart on a parchment paper-covered baking sheet. To pipe the mounds, hold the pastry bag at a slight angle and allow the tip to touch the parchment as you begin to pipe. Once you have formed the mound, stop squeezing and lift the tip straight up, leaving a small tail on the top of each mound. You can also use a spoon and drop small mounds of ganache onto the baking sheet. Let the truffles harden at room temperature for a couple of hours (or in the refrigerator for 15 minutes), until they are hard enough to roll with your hands.

When I roll the truffles, I usually wear surgical gloves. The gloves are not mandatory but if you do not use them, be sure your hands are very clean. To roll the mound into a ball, place a truffle between both palms, squeeze slightly, and roll between your hands. The truffles will look nicer if they are as round as possible. When all the truffles are rolled into balls, they are ready to be coated. If they have become too soft, place them in the refrigerator for 1 to 2 hours until they are firm enough to dip.

You can use either a dipping fork or your hands to dip the truffles in chocolate. To use the fork, drop the truffle into the bowl of tempered chocolate and then retrieve it with the dipping fork. Hold the fork over the bowl for several seconds to allow the excess chocolate to drip back into the bowl. Gently scrape the bottom of the fork against the side of the bowl to remove any excess chocolate and roll the dipped truffle in the desired garnish. Place on a parchment paper-covered baking sheet. If you use your hands, dab some chocolate in the palm of one hand. Roll the truffle in that palm to completely coat it with chocolate. Place the

enrobed truffle on the baking sheet. Repeat for the remaining truffles. This method is very quick but it can also be extremely messy.

When all of the truffles have been coated once, repeat the enrobing procedure. This is necessary only when you enrobe the truffles by hand rather than with a fork. The truffles are usually more evenly coated when dipped with a fork. As soon as each truffle gets a second coating, immediately roll it in the desired garnish. You need to do this before the chocolate sets or the topping will not adhere. At this stage, it is good to have a friend help because it is hard to dip and roll at the same time. Place the truffles on a clean parchment paper-covered baking sheet and allow them to set, about 5 minutes.

The truffles will keep for up to 2 weeks at room temperature, when stored in an airtight container.

Notes:

If you decide to roll the truffles by hand, it is important to make sure your hands are cold. A good trick is to dip your hands in ice water for a few seconds and then dry them. Do this immediately before rolling the truffles. If your hands are too warm and the truffles begin to melt while you are rolling them, re-dip your hands in the ice water, dry them, and proceed.

To toast coconut: Preheat the oven to 400°F (204°C). Spread the coconut on a baking sheet and place in the oven for about 3 minutes. Remove from the oven and stir to keep the sugar in the coconut from burning. Return to the oven and toast until golden brown, about 3 more minutes. Remove the baking sheet from the oven and cool on a wire rack.

To toast nuts: Preheat oven to 300°F (148°C). Spread the nuts evenly on a baking sheet and place in the oven. Toast for about 30 minutes, until they are golden brown. You will be able to smell the nuts when they are ready. A good test is to break a nut in half and check to see if it is light brown on the inside. Toasting nuts brings out their natural flavor. Remove them from the oven and allow to cool completely on the baking sheet on a wire rack.

Yield: About 180 truffles

TEMPERING CHOCOLATE

Tempering determines the final gloss, hardness, and contraction of the chocolate. When you melt chocolate, the molecules of fat separate. To put them back together, you temper it. There are a variety of ways to do it.

One of the easiest ways is to place it in the microwave for 30 seconds at a time on high power until the chocolate is melted. Be very careful not to overheat it. The chocolate will not look as if it has melted because it retains its shape. It should be only slightly warmer than your bottom lip. You may still see lumps in it, but don't worry; the residual heat of the chocolate will melt them. You can also use an immersion blender to break up the lumps and start the recrystallization process.

Usually, the chocolate begins to set (recrystallize) along the side of the bowl. As it begins to crystallize, mix those crystals into the melted chocolate and they will begin the recrystallization process. I like to use a glass bowl because it retains the heat and keeps the chocolate tempered for a long time.

Another way to temper chocolate is called *seeding*. In this method, tempering is achieved by adding small pieces of unmelted chocolate to melted chocolate. The amount of unmelted chocolate to be added depends on the temperature of the melted chocolate but is usually one fourth of the total amount. I usually use an immersion blender to mix the two together.

The classic way to temper chocolate is called *tabliering*. Chocolate is melted over a hot water bath to a temperature between 88°F and 90°F (31°C and 32°C). (White and milk chocolate are melted to a temperature approximately 2°F less, depending on the amount of milk fat they contain.) Two thirds of the melted chocolate is poured on a cold table or marble surface. The chocolate is spread out and worked with a spatula until the temperature of the chocolate is approximately 81°F (27°C). At this stage, it is thick and begins to set. This tempered chocolate is then added to the remaining one third of nontempered chocolate and mixed thoroughly until the mass in the bowl has a completely uniform temperature. If the temperature is still too high, part of the chocolate is further worked on the cold table until the correct temperature is reached. This is a lot of work, requires a lot of room, and makes a big mess.

A simple method to check tempering is to apply a small quantity of chocolate to a piece of paper or to the point of a knife. If the chocolate has been tempered correctly, it will harden evenly and show a good gloss within 5 minutes.